

developed into a really wonderful place. And Darlinghurst is on the fringe of Surry Hills, which is booming, and unquestionably lovely. Darlinghurst is just a little gritty, and I love that. It will improve more and more.

It's about being a little bit left of centre to find something that is more affordable than the really popular areas. Find an area you see has potential, which is not always the most attractive area at the time, and if you can see that it has room for improvement, that is a good place to start.

2. Natural light and ventilation

'This is really valuable, that sense of being able to illuminate the spaces all through the apartment during the day.' Windows should open, with a connection to a balcony or a terrace. The more north-facing the apartment, to exploit the sunlight, the better, Richards says.

3. High ceilings

These lend an additional sensation of space and airiness.

4. Entry area

A hallway or foyer – however much a compact interpretation of what is in a house – will delineate spaces and is a functional need (for example, somewhere to put your keys and bag), Richards says. This won't be a feature of every apartment, especially the more economically sized ones, but if your apartment has it, it's a bonus.

5. Finishes

The durability of materials is key for maintaining looks and value, so run your hands over surfaces to determine telltale signs of quality and workmanship – texture and warmth. These are subjective decisions, Richards says; for him, a substitute 'plastic feel' timber floor, as opposed to natural wood, and an engineered stone bench over natural stone, are no-noes. 'This is a telling sign; if you can see substitutions that are not the real thing, it is a total turn-off. I would not really go any further. You are going to live in it for a while and it needs to maintain its value, so having the quality of materials is essential.'